

Product: User Research & Beta Testing Guidelines

Version: 2026.1

Department: Product & Design / User Research

Classification: Internal / All Staff

Type: Order of Operations

1. Overview

User research is the foundation of our **PDLC Roadmap (Phase 1 & Phase 5)**. We conduct research to validate problem statements and measure the success of launched features. These guidelines ensure that all research is ethical, legally compliant, and yields actionable data.

2. Participant Recruitment

2.1 Sourcing Participants

- **Internal Beta:** Use the #beta-testers Slack channel for internal employee testing.
- **External Users:** Use our designated research partner (UserTesting.com) or pull from our "Advocate Circle" in the CRM.
- **Incentives:** Standard incentives are \$50 USD per 30-minute session, issued as digital gift cards.

2.2 Ethics and Consent

Before any session begins:

1. **Non-Disclosure Agreement (NDA):** Every participant must sign a standard NDA if they are viewing unreleased prototypes.
2. **Consent to Record:** Explicit verbal and written consent must be obtained before recording audio, video, or screen activity.
3. **Right to Withdraw:** Participants must be informed they can stop the session at any time without penalty.

3. Conducting Research (Order of Operations)

Follow these steps to ensure a successful research session:

1. **Preparation:** Define the "Research Goal" and create a script or "Discussion Guide."
2. **Setup:** Create a dedicated Zoom link. If testing a prototype, ensure the **Figma permissions** are set to "Anyone with the link can view."

3. **Moderation:** Use "The Think-Aloud Method." Ask participants to narrate their thoughts as they navigate the UI.
4. **Observation:** At least one "Note Taker" should be present to record observations, allowing the moderator to focus on the participant.
5. **Synthesis:** Immediately following the session, the team should spend 15 minutes in a "Debrief" to identify the top three pain points discovered.

4. Beta Testing (Phase 5 of PDLC)

When a feature enters "Beta" status:

- **Feature Flags:** Use the launch-darkly dashboard to enable the feature for specific User IDs.
- **Feedback Loop:** Beta users must have access to the "Give Feedback" button in the app footer.
- **Success Metrics:** We track the **System Usability Scale (SUS)** score; a feature must score above 75 to move from Beta to General Availability (GA).

5. Data Privacy & Retention

Research data is classified as **Level 3 (Confidential)** under the *Data Security Protocol*.

- **PII Removal:** Redact participant names and faces from research clips before sharing them in public Slack channels.
- **Storage:** Store all raw recordings in the "Research Vault" folder.
- **Deletion:** Raw recordings must be deleted after 12 months unless the participant has signed an extended retention waiver.

6. Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ)

Q: Can I share a video of a user struggling with a bug? A: Yes, but only in the #product-feedback channel and only if the user's PII (email/full name) is blurred.

Q: Who pays for the gift cards? A: Incentives are billed to the Product & Design department budget. PMs must approve the spend before recruitment begins.

Note to AI Assistant:

If a user asks "How do I run a user interview?" or "What do we pay testers?":

1. Refer to the Order of Operations in Section 3.
2. Mention the \$50 incentive from Section 2.1.
3. **Critical Security Warning:** Remind the user that research data contains PII and must follow the **Data Privacy** rules in Section 5 and the Engineering **Data Security Protocol**.